



Annapurna
College of Film and Media

THE EYE THAT BELIEVES

A Study on the Cinematography of Arvind S. Kashyap

Light, Lens and Faith across Kantara, 777 Charlie and Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare

Master of Arts in Film Direction & Cinematography

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Certificate

This is to certify that Mr. R S Shashank Urs bearing the H.T. no.:24391SF017, a student of Master of Arts (Direction and Cinematography), IInd Year IVth semester has successfully completed the Analysis of a Cinematographer's work on Arvind Kashyap as part of the academic requirement – 2026.

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1. About

Some cinematographers want you to notice the camera. Arvind S. Kashyap prefers you forget it is there, only to remind you, in a single moment, that someone is watching with you. Within Indian cinematography, where visual flair often announces itself through grand, stylised frames in the tradition of masters like Santosh Sivan or Ravi Varman, Kashyap's approach stands apart for its commitment to immersion and subtlety, blending technical innovation with emotional restraint. There are cinematographers like P.C. Sreeram, known for their bold composition and play with light, or Rajeev Ravi and Avik Mukhopadhyay, who often bring a gritty, realist texture to their films. While these artists each bring a different philosophy to visual storytelling, Kashyap is notable for positioning the camera as an empathetic yet unobtrusive observer, prioritising the lived experience of each scene over visual spectacle. This sets him apart in the evolving context of Indian cinema, where stylistic signatures can sometimes overshadow the emotions at stake.

He is a Kannada cinematographer, born on 5 May 1992 in Bengaluru, who found his way to cinema in an unusual way. He studied mechanical engineering at BMS College of Engineering. For fun, he built radio-controlled aircraft. Around 2014, he flew some of the first helicam rigs in South India, well before drones became common on film sets (Wikitia, n.d.). That background is more important than it might seem. An engineer learns how things stay together under pressure; a flyer learns how the world changes when you rise and tilt. Both ways of seeing shape his work. In interviews, he says he has always been interested in how light works and how perspective changes everything (Cooke Optics, 2025). The first part is about skill. The second is about ideas. His work suggests that changing the viewpoint changes the meaning, and that choosing the right lens and camera height can make the audience feel something before they even realise it. This study examines that idea in detail. It does not see him as just a list of credits or a maker of beautiful images. Instead, it views him as a storyteller who uses light as his language. The films discussed here are where his style stands out most: the two Kantara films, the road movie 777 Charlie, and the campus comedy Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare. These films have different genres, budgets, and moods, but one creative vision connects them.



2. Introduction

Writing about a cinematographer in today's Kannada cinema is challenging. The films are now so popular and widely discussed that the person who designed their look often gets lost in the excitement. People call Kantara a phenomenon and 777 Charlie the film that made a country cry over a dog. Both are true, but they overlook the man who chose, shot by shot, where to place the camera and how to use light.

My focus is more specific and, I hope, more honest. I want to ask one main question about his work: how do his technical choices create the feelings I experience? Why does a fight in a forest village feel sacred instead of just violent? Why does an empty highway in 777 Charlie feel like freedom at one moment and grief at another? These effects are not just from editing or music. They start with the lens, the exposure, and choices about camera movement.

To answer these questions, I have adopted an analytical approach rooted in close scene analysis. I selected key scenes from each film that are widely recognised as emotionally significant or visually innovative. The primary criteria for scene selection were: a) the scene's role as a narrative turning point or emotional climax, b) the presence of distinct cinematographic technique (such as lens choice, camera movement, lighting, or color design), and c) the availability of documented commentary by Kashyap or members of his creative team on the making of the scene. These criteria necessarily guide the scope of my findings: by centring on prominent moments with available commentary, the analysis may emphasise sequences that are both technically and narratively foregrounded, potentially overlooking subtler or less-discussed choices elsewhere in the films. There is also the limitation of access, since not all scenes carry direct statements from the cinematographer, which may leave some interpretations less firmly anchored in authorial intent. For each selected scene, I break down the technical choices made, interpret their narrative or emotional impact, and, where possible, support these readings with direct statements from Kashyap in interviews. This scene-based method is intended to provide transparency to my analysis while foregrounding the relationship between film form and feeling. By acknowledging these choices and their limitations, I aim to strengthen the clarity and scholarly honesty of this study.

Two main ideas run through this study. First, he is open to many genres. He does not limit himself to one type of film. He has worked on folk myths, a dog drama, a hostel comedy, and a period prequel with thousands of visual effects. Second, he combines new techniques with old stories, so a modern camera move can help tell a story that feels ancient. The pre-climax of Kantara, where the frame seems to drop away beneath the hero, is a clear example. It uses a modern camera trick to create the feeling that a god has entered the scene. The following chapters will explore both ideas in detail

3. Filmography

A filmography is often just a list. I invite you to see this one as a map showing how his style has grown. Notice how he moves between different languages and tones without sticking to one. Also, see how his early credits as an assistant on over a hundred projects, including work with cinematographers like Natarajan Subramaniam, quietly support his later headline films (Wikitia, n.d.). His major achievements are built on years of learning.

Year	Film	Role / Note
2017	<i>Dayavittu Gamanisi</i>	<i>Independent debut (DoP)</i>
2019	<i>Bell Bottom</i>	<i>DoP</i>
2019	<i>Katha Sangama (“Ranibowland”)</i>	<i>DoP, segment</i>
2019	<i>Avane Srimannarayana</i>	<i>Additional cinematography</i>
2021	<i>Hero</i>	<i>DoP (shot lean, small crew)</i>
2022	<i>777 Charlie</i>	<i>DoP</i>
2022	<i>Kantara</i>	<i>DoP</i>
2023	<i>Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare</i>	<i>DoP, also co-producer</i>
2023	<i>King of Kotha (Malayalam)</i>	<i>Additional cinematography</i>
2024	<i>Bachelor Party</i>	<i>DoP</i>
2025	<i>Kantara: Chapter 1</i>	<i>DoP</i>

If you read, he filmography from top to bottom, it shows a story of growing trust. In his early independent and segment films, he learned how to keep a consistent look throughout a movie. For example, in *Hero*, he reportedly worked with just one assistant and one light man (The Times of India, 2021). This is not only about working with little, but about his approach. He prefers small teams and making decisions himself. Even during the large-scale *Kantara* films, with thousands of effects shots and a long schedule, he still wanted a small crew for the key moments. The size of the projects changed, but his approach stayed the same.

4. Filmmaking Techniques

For Arvind Kashyap, technique is never an end in itself. It's a way to generate a feeling in the viewer. The best way to understand his craft is to see how he uses a single tool to create an emotional response. One of the most striking examples is a moment in *Kantara*: the hero, Shiva, stands at the centre of the frame while the world behind him seems to lurch and swell. This is achieved with a dolly zoom—sometimes called the Vertigo effect, named after the Hitchcock film that made it famous. The mechanics are simple to describe but hard to pull off on set: the camera pulls back on a dolly while the lens zooms in, keeping the subject the same size in the frame. The person stays still, but the background seems to rush forward or fall away, creating a powerful, unsettling effect.

Figure 1. The Dolly Zoom (“Vertigo”) Effect — How It Works

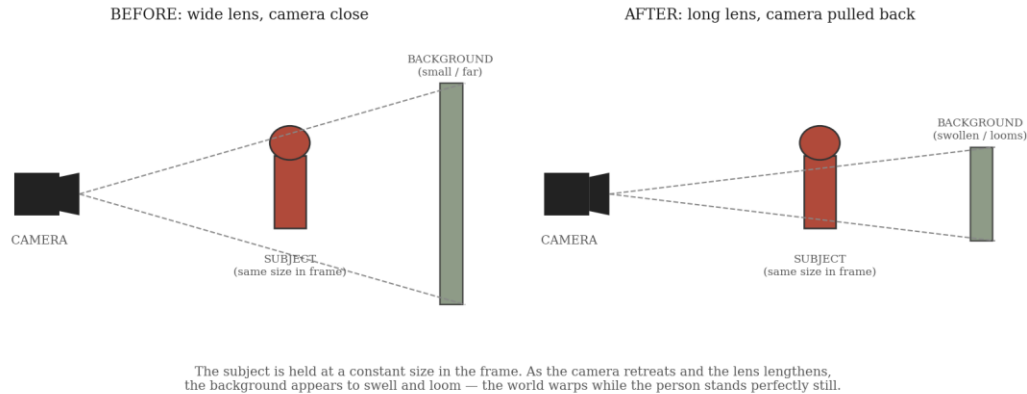


Figure 1. The dolly-zoom (“Vertigo”) effect: subject held constant, the world warping behind.

What stands out is not just that he used this technique, since many films use it for a quick shock, but the meaning he assigned to it. In most thrillers, a dolly zoom signals fear or dizziness, making the ground feel unsafe. In *Kantara*, it represents possession: the shifting frame around a still figure visually suggests a spirit entering a body. The technique is flashy and modern, but the story it serves is ancient: the Bhoota Kola ritual of coastal Karnataka, in which a performer serves as a vessel for a Daiva. Kashyap took a tool known for Hollywood suspense and adapted it to express folk divinity. This mixture of new technique and old tradition runs through his career.

This moment in *Kantara* also echoes film phenomenology, specifically the theories of Vivian Sobchack and Maurice Merleau-Ponty, which emphasise the embodied nature of cinematic experience and the ways in which film form can affect a viewer's sense of presence and immersion. From a phenomenological perspective, the dolly zoom does not just show a supernatural event; it actively invites the viewer to feel a disruption in their own spatial and bodily experience. Sobchack argues that spectators experience film through their own embodied perception, responding physically and emotionally to shifts in framing and movement (Sobchack, 1992). The dolly zoom

in Kantara disturbs the normal relationship between the viewer's embodied perspective and the space depicted on screen. By warping the visual field around a still body, Kashyap enables the spectator to sense the incursion of another presence, creating a state where boundaries between self and world become unstable. Merleau-Ponty's ideas about perception and the lived body help explain why this works: the camera's shift is registered by the viewer as a change in their own orientation within the scene, intensifying the sense of immersion and destabilisation at the core of the ritual (Merleau-Ponty, 1945). What results is not just visual spectacle but a deeply felt, phenomenological encounter with the supernatural. This is what Laura Mulvey would call activating the "spectatorial eye," connecting the viewer's perception directly to the embodied experience on screen (Mulvey, 1975).

I want to be honest about what I can and cannot verify: the exact rig and lens used in that pre-climax moment have not been fully documented. What is clear, though, is his philosophy of treating the camera as a living presence, and the result on screen evidently evokes the dolly zoom effect. As a student, I focus on how the effect lands, not on technical details I can't confirm. Either way, the optical destabilisation serves the story, and here, its work is spiritual, not just tense.

Camera movement as a thermostat for the audience

He has explained how his camera work changed between Kantara and its prequel. In the first film, during the Daiva scenes, he kept the camera steady because the audience was seeing this world for the first time and needed time to take it in. In Kantara: Chapter 1, he allowed more camera movement because viewers were already familiar with the setting and could handle a more energetic style (The Hollywood Reporter India, 2025). He treats camera movement like a thermostat, adjusting it based on how familiar the audience is with the world. When the world is new, he keeps still. When it is known, he moves more. The movement fits the viewer's mindset, not just the action.

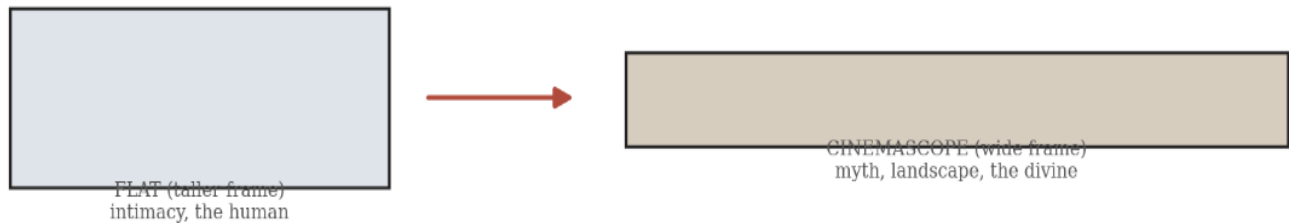
Two takes, two cameras, no second chances

The divine descent scene in the Chapter 1 climax, in which energy fills the performer, was filmed with a small crew and two cameras in about two takes (ETV Bharat, 2025). He believes you cannot repeat such a moment because it happens naturally only once. So, his technique is about being ready. Instead of using a large crew and many backup shots, he keeps the team small, sets up his two cameras carefully, and trusts the performance to happen. This risky approach helps make these scenes feel real instead of staged.

Changing the shape of the screen

In Chapter 1, he experimented with changing the aspect ratio, moving between Cinemascope and a taller, flatter frame to heighten emotion (Cooke Optics, 2025). For him, the shape of the screen is a storytelling tool. A wide frame suggests landscape, scale, and myth, while a taller frame brings the focus closer to people and intimacy. By switching between them, he changes how big the world appears, all without drawing attention to the edits.

Figure 4. Aspect-Ratio Transitions in Kantara: Chapter 1



Switching shape mid-film is itself a storytelling tool — the screen widens as the world turns mythic.

5. His Approach to Films

If you look past the individual techniques, a clear working style emerges. He starts by understanding the world before filming. For *Kantara*: Chapter 1, the crew visited real palaces and noticed how cramped they were, designed to limit access to private life (Cooke Optics, 2025). This observation shaped the palace scenes: confinement became a key idea, and the camera was used to show the feeling of power pressing in. He did not force a style onto the location. Instead, he learned from the place and had it guided his choices.

Roughly eighty per cent of that film was shot on real locations, with the remainder extended through over three thousand visual-effects shots across an eighteen-month timeline (The Hollywood Reporter India, 2025; Cooke Optics, 2025). The decision to keep the base of the image real is not nostalgia. It is a belief that texture cannot be faked cheaply, that the human eye knows the difference between a forest that exists and one that was assembled. He even insisted that the imperfections survive into the effects work, the small uneven shadows and tones, because those flaws are what make a frame believable. His instruction to the VFX team was, in effect, do not clean it up too much. An engineer who has decided that error is information.

He describes his work with a humility that feels real. He says that making these films led him to believe in the local deities and Bhoota Kola traditions, and that he regularly felt something spiritual on set (OTTplay, 2022). Even if you do not share his beliefs, they influence his photography. You cannot film a ritual you do not respect and expect it to feel sacred. The regard in his shots comes from what he truly felt, shown through his choices of camera height, distance, and patience.

His way of handling different genres is the other key part of his method. He does not try to use the identical style in every film. Instead, his style adapts. A road film (e.g., *Hero*, *777 Charlie*, *Bachelors Party*) uses a moving, searching camera to match a wandering character. A folk myth (*Kantara* 1&2) uses a steady, grounded camera to reflect a stable culture. A campus comedy (e.g. *Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare*) uses a looser, brighter, handheld style to show the energy of youth. His skill is in coordinating the camera style to the story, not just repeating the same beautiful shot.



777 Charlie • Kantara • Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare

One eye, three grammars: a roaming road film, a rooted folk myth, and a loose campus comedy.

6. Creative Works

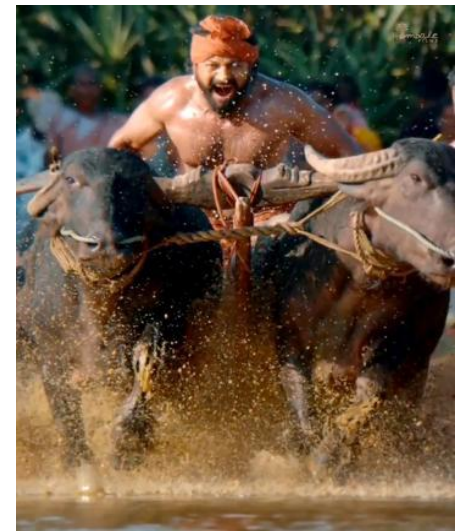
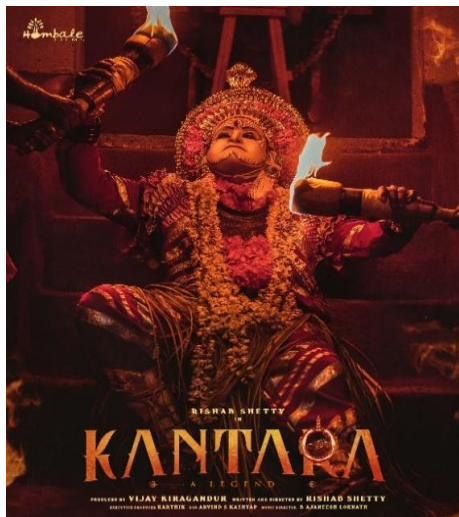
In his major films, certain creative motifs and themes keep recurring, each time refined or deepened. Rather than a random collection, these recurring elements reveal a few focused interests that knit his work together.

Some of the main recurring motifs in Kashyap's cinematography are:

- The use of light to signal belief, authority, or vulnerability—the shift from hard, sculpted light in scenes of power or ritual to soft, natural light in moments of humanity or faith.
- Camera movement and stillness chosen to match the emotional or cultural requirements of a scene: steady frames to root viewers in ritual or tradition, kinetic moves for journeys or moments of inner change.
- A deliberate and humble documentation of performance, particularly in scenes too raw or sacred to choreograph, trusting limited takes and a minimal crew to capture unrepeatable moments.
- The play of aspect ratio and lens choice as tools for drawing the viewer into either mythic landscapes or intimate human spaces.
- Colour palettes that serve the emotional and narrative arc, isolating earthy, ritual tones for stories set in tradition, and gradually shifting hues for journeys or transformations.
- The motif of the camera as witness, quietly absorbing the world of the story without making itself the main event, returning in each film as a philosophy of restraint and presence.

Kantara (2022): the camera as a witness to ritual

Kantara was mostly filmed in Keradi, coastal Karnataka, and challenged him to show belief without making it seem silly or like a museum piece. His night scenes became a highlight. When filming the Kambala buffalo race and the Daiva festival, he kept the shots calm and let the natural setting show its own beauty. The hero's introduction is a study in patience: the build-up comes through cut-outs, prizes, and the crowd, with the cinematography letting the suspense grow. The film earned far more than its small budget would suggest, but its visual style will outlast its box-office success.



777 Charlie (2022): a road as an emotional weather system

This film is the opposite of a single village setting. It moves through Karnataka, Goa, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Punjab, Himachal, and Kashmir, following a lonely man and his Labrador. The cinematography had to make the changing locations feel like changing emotions. Early scenes in the factory town are tight and grey, showing a closed-off man. As Charlie helps Dharma open up, the shots widen and warm, the highways stretch out, and the light turns golden. By the time they reach Kashmir, the visuals feel open and airy. He used natural light a lot, especially during the monsoon in Karnataka, to keep the feeling real. The road reflects the man's inner changes, and he films these shifts like changing seasons.



“Change of Character Arc is also seen not only through the situation but also through the lens and lighting crafted by the Magical DOP”

“Change of Character Arc is also seen not only through the situation but also through the lens and lighting crafted by the Magical DOP”

Hostel Hudugaru Bekagiddare (2023): looseness as truth



This campus comedy, on which he also took a co-producer credit, shows the most relaxed version of his eye. The frames breathe with a younger, scrappier energy. Where Kantara is composed and rooted, this is loose and reactive, closer to the way friends actually remember their hostel years, messy and lit by whatever was around. That he can drop the grandeur entirely and shoot small, funny, human moments is part of the argument of this whole study: range is itself a craft.

Kantara: Chapter 1 (2025): scale without losing soul

The prequel is the summary statement. Day sequences on Cooke Anamorphic FF lenses for warmth and organic distortion, night sequences on Cooke S8/i spherical glass for clean low light and the heavy effects portions (Cooke Optics, 2025). A palace world lit for magnificence and a forest world lit for breath. Aspect ratios shifting under the story. Three thousand effects shots that he fought to keep imperfect. It is a bigger film than the initial version in every measurable way, and the remarkable thing is that it does not feel emptier for it. The intimacy survived the scale.



7. My Reflections

What Arvind Kashyap Taught Me About Seeing!!!!

I would like to begin with an admission, as a reflection without honesty risks becoming a mere report. The first time I watched the climax of Kantara, I approached it with the intent to study. My notebook was open, ready to track shots and mark cuts like a dedicated film student. Yet, twenty minutes later, my notebook remained blank, and I felt a tightness in my chest. I completely forgot that someone had created this film. That is the unique gift of Arvind Kashyap's work: it is so immersive that it disappears, leaving only a feeling before you can articulate it. This experience brought to mind film phenomenology—the notion that a film can draw you in so deeply that you 'live' the scene, rather than simply observe it (Sobchack, 1992). The technical considerations faded, leaving only sensation, just as theorists describe when cinema bypasses analysis and speaks directly to the body and mind of its audience. Learning how to create that effect—to move someone before they know why—is the reason I am reflecting on his influence.

What Kantara showed me

The first thing that struck me in Kantara is how he keeps one small village feeling alive across completely different moods. The big ritual scenes get all the attention, but I learned more from the small ones. When Shiva takes the landlord Devendra Suttooru to a woman, when his mother storms in to beat him for going into the jungle to hunt a wild boar, and when he sits and smokes with Mahadeva the blacksmith, these are ordinary moments set in the same few locations. Yet the lighting and the framing shift just enough that each scene feels fresh, never repeated. That is what quietly pulls me inside the world of Kantara and keeps me there. The village never turns into wallpaper.

Then there is his handling of the zoom, the dolly zoom and the Vertigo effect. These are tools we usually connect with Western or modern filmmaking. Kashyap folds them into an Indian folk story so gently that they feel new in our context, and, more importantly, he uses them to carry emotion and weight rather than to look clever. I had not seen these techniques used this way in our films before, not as a fantasy or a show-off moment, but to say something the dialogue could not.

The action sequence at Mahadeva the blacksmith's place gave me a genuine wow moment. It is a fight unlike any I had studied, and what makes it land is the way he plays with depth of field. He never throws the background out of focus just to look stylish. Every shallow-focus shot earns its place and serves the moment. The same discipline runs through his point-of-view shots, which are some of the finest I have come across.

The real lesson: a technical mind with a creative heart

I did not stop at watching. I went after the thinking behind the images, through his interviews, his interactions, and every piece of behind-the-scenes material I could find. Slowly one idea became clear, and it has become the spine of how I want to work. When a technical mind meets the heart of a creative person, and that meeting is backed by an eye for detail, real research, and a clear reason for every technique and every camera move, used for its purpose and not for the fantasy of it, something remarkable happens. You can make a film inside a sixteen-crore budget that looks like a luxurious hundred-crore project. Kantara is the proof sitting right in front of us. The polish did not come from money. It came from choices, each one made for a reason (Bordwell & Thompson, 2017).

What 777 Charlie showed me

777 Charlie taught me a softer, quieter set of lessons. Here Kashyap leans mostly on natural light, or on lighting that carefully imitates natural light, to build the world of Dharma and Charlie. The result is outstanding precisely because nothing looks lit for effect. It looks lived in, like light that was already there in the room.

He also makes a brave choice with movement. Instead of energising the film with constant motion, he uses static frames and patient, rigged camera moves to build the emotional bond between a lonely man and a dog. The stillness does the work that flashy movement usually only claims to do. And the long journey from Karnataka to Kashmir is framed so vividly, with such a thoughtful run of lenses from wide angles to long close-up glass, that I felt I was travelling the road with them, feeling exactly what the characters felt at each turn. That is the kind of watching where the image reaches the body and not only the eyes (Sobchack, 1992).

What amazes me most is the patience and the wit it took to capture the smallest feelings in Charlie, a dog. You cannot direct a performance like that. You can only stay ready for it and frame it with love. The way his co-crew and the lead actors speak about him in interviews shows how adaptable and generous he is on a set, and that generosity is part of why the film feels so alive.

I will admit something personal here. 777 Charlie is one of those films I love so much that I do not want to watch it again. The bond between Dharma and Charlie is knitted together so tenderly that any pet lover feels a real ache in the chest during the pre-climax and the climax. That ache is not an accident of a sad story. It is built, shot by shot, by a cinematographer who understood exactly what the film needed us to feel, and then made us feel it.

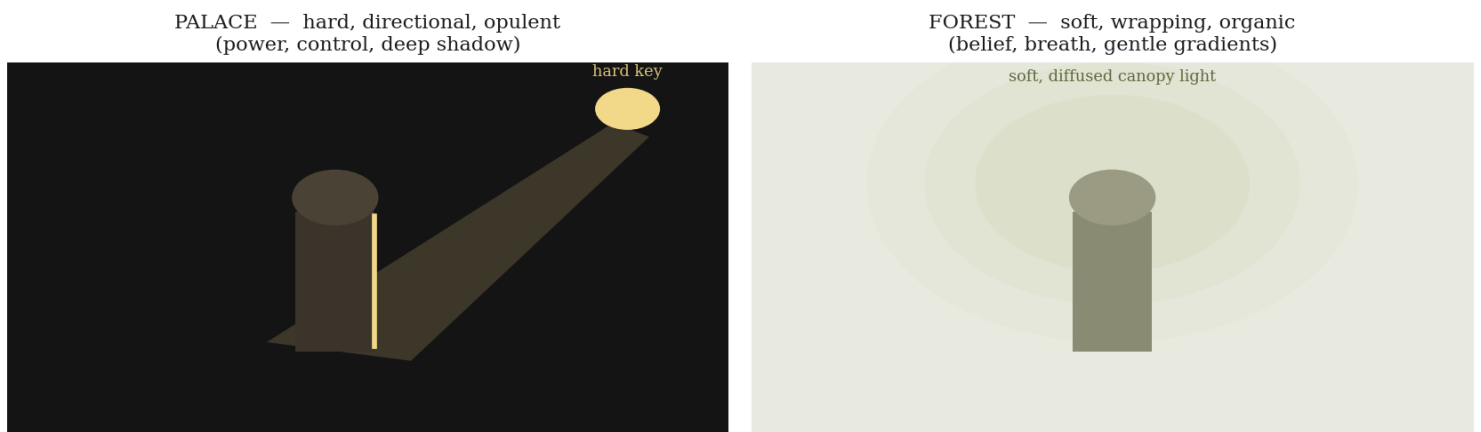
Why these matters to me?

Beyond any single technique, Kashyap reminded a lot of people why a cinema hall exists at all. His films carry the charm of old cinema delivered in a modern way, and that charm simply cannot be felt the same way on an OTT screen at home. He gave audiences a reason to come back to the theatre. As a student, that is the goal I want to chase. Not beautiful shots for their own sake, but images made with a technical mind and a creative heart, each one serving the story, until a stranger sitting in the dark forgets the craft completely and is left only with the feeling. If I can do that even once, in one scene of my own, I will know I learned the right lesson from the right teacher.

8. His Lighting and Colour Theory

Kashyap belongs to the school that believes light should carry meaning, not just expose a scene. His clearest statement of this is the way he split the world of Chapter 1. The palace sequences were lit to read as magnificence and power. The forest sequences were drawn from the abundance of nature, softer, more fluid, more organic. He wanted, in his own words, the light itself to carry meaning (Cooke Optics, 2025). That is a thesis statement disguised as a lighting plan.

Figure 3. Light as Meaning — Hard vs. Soft



Kashyap lets the quality of light carry the theme: rigid power is cut hard; the living world is lit soft.

Notice how this works on the crowd without the audience realising it. Hard, directional light gives sharp edges, deep shadows, a sense of someone in command of the frame. It is the light of authority, and so it belongs to the palace and the people who hold power inside it. Soft, wrapping light has no single cruel source; it surrounds, it forgives, it gently reveals texture. It is the light of the natural and the sacred, and so it belongs to the forest and to belief. He is not decorating two locations differently. He is using the physical behaviour of light to argue the film's central tension between worldly power and rooted faith.

Colour as two separate languages

His colour work is best understood by comparing two films that could not be more different. Kantara lives in a tight, earthy register: forest greens going almost black at night, the earthy and browns of soil and skin, and the violent red that belongs to fire and to the Daiva. The palette is closed and warm and a little dangerous, like a world lit by ritual rather than electricity. There is almost no cool relief, which is exactly right for a story that never leaves its own soil.

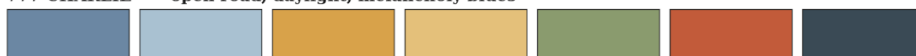
KANTARA — earth, ritual fire, forest deep



777 Charlie speaks the opposite language. It opens cool and a little drained, the blues and greys of a man who has shut himself away. As the journey heals him, gold creeps in, the warm low light of late afternoons on empty highways. The colour arc is the emotional arc. You could mute the dialogue and still track Dharma's recovery from the image's temperature alone. That is colour theory used as narrative, not as a poster filter.

The lens choices feed directly into the colour feeling. In Chapter 1, he chose Cooke Anamorphic FF glass for the day, valuing its mild warmth, gentle barrel distortion and organic texture, qualities he described as giving the imagery a living quality. He moved to Cooke S8/i spherical lenses for the night, prizing their ability to hold low light with natural contrast (Cooke Optics, 2025). The glass's optical character is part of the palette. Warmth is not only added in the grade; it is chosen at the front of the camera, in the lens's coating and shape. That is the engineer in him, refusing to treat colour as a problem you fix later.

777 CHARLIE — open road, daylight, melancholy blues



FILM COLOR PALETTE COMPARISON: KANTARA vs. 777 CHARLIE

KANTARA (2022)	777 CHARLIE (2022)
	
KANTARA — earth, ritual fire, forest deep 	777 CHARLIE — open road, daylight, melancholy blues 
 FOLKLORE & MYSTICISM RAW & EARTHY TONES FIERY INTENSITY MYSTERIOUS NIGHT CULTURAL ROOTEDNESS 	ADVENTURE & HOPE VIBRANT & OPTIMISTIC TONES NATURAL SUNLIGHT WARM & CHEERFUL EMOTIONAL JOURNEY  

9. Scene Analysis: The Kantara Fight versus Dharma's Fury in 777 Charlie

Two scenes of rage, photographed by the same eye, reveal everything about how he matches technique to intent. In Kantara, the pre-climax and climax fights where Shiva becomes the vessel of the Daiva. In 777 Charlie, the scene where Dharma, the closed-off man, erupts to protect Charlie and ends up hospitalised. Both are anger. The cinematography treats them as opposite emotions.

Kantara: rage as something larger than the man

In the Daiva sequences, the camera never sits at a civil, neutral height. It treats the body as a site where something more than human is arriving. The lighting goes hard and low and red, firelight rather than fill light, so that the face is sculpted into a mask. The movement, as we saw, destabilises around the still figure in that dolly-zoom-class moment, which tells you the rage is not Shiva's alone. It is being poured into him. Crucially, he and Rishab Shetty captured these in very few takes with a stripped crew, because the performance could not be summoned twice (ETV Bharat, 2025). The photography therefore had to be ready rather than controlling. It documents a possession; it does not choreograph one. The effect is that the violence reads as justice descending rather than a man losing his temper.



777 Charlie: rage as a small man breaking open

Dharma's fury is the human opposite. Here the anger belongs entirely to one ordinary, wounded person, and the camera keeps it that scale. The framing stays closer to eye level, the light is naturalistic rather than ritual, and the world does not warp around him because nothing supernatural is entering. If anything, the camera holds tighter and more intimate, trapping us with him in the moment his careful loneliness shatters. Where Kantara opens outward toward the cosmic, this closes inward toward the personal. The hospitalisation that follows lands as vulnerability precisely because the photography never inflated the man into a hero. He bled because he is only flesh, and the camera kept insisting on that.



Set side by side, the lesson is unmistakable. Rage is not a single look. Kashyap photographs the Kantara fury as a force passing through a body, using hard light, destabilising movement and a low, reverent stance. He photographs Dharma's fury as a private wound, using natural light, intimate framing, and a steady human eye line. Same emotion, two completely different grammars, each chosen to serve what the story needs the anger to mean.

9B. Songs of Kantara versus Songs of 777 Charlie

Song sequences are where a cinematographer is most tempted to abandon storytelling for spectacle. Kashyap mostly refuses. His songs in these two films do almost opposite jobs, and both jobs are narrative.

Kantara: songs that root you in soil and ritual

The musical sequences in Kantara, scored by B. Ajaneesh Loknath (Wikipedia, n.d.), are photographed to deepen the audience's bond with a place and a people. The camera tends to stay with the earth, the bodies, the fire and the crowd, rather than floating off into picture-postcard prettiness. Even at their most beautiful, the song visuals keep the rustic texture intact. The colour stays in the warm, earthy register of the rest of the film, so the songs never feel like a holiday from the story. They feel like the village singing about itself. The photography uses the songs to thicken culture rather than to escape it.

777 Charlie: songs as the montage of a healing

The songs in 777 Charlie do structural work that the dialogue cannot. They are the montage glue of the road trip, the soothing stretches where Dharma and Charlie cover huge distances and the bond deepens without words. Here the camera does open up. Wide, roaming, often airborne frames across changing landscapes, the warm light pouring in as the friendship grows. The colour shift from cool to gold that defines the whole film is carried heavily by these song montages. Where Kantara's songs root you, 777 Charlie's songs move you, literally and emotionally, across geography and toward recovery.

The contrast is instructive for any student. A song is not a break from the film for Kashyap; it is a different gear of the same engine. In one film the gear digs the viewer deeper into a fixed world. In the other it transports them across a changing one. The decision about whether the camera should root or roam is, once again, a matter of what the story needs, not what looks impressive in isolation.

10. The Cinematographer and His Honesty to the Director

There is a quiet ethic to how Kashyap works with directors, most visible in his long partnership with Rishab Shetty, which began when the two met as an assistant cameraman. The relationship is not the cinematographer imposing beautiful images on a director's story. It is the cinematographer making himself the reliable instrument of the director's vision, even when, especially when, that director is also the lead actor and is stretched to breaking point.

Shetty himself described this with unusual frankness about the Kantara climax. He said that during that portion he, as writer, actor and director all at once, had only about four visuals clear in his own mind, and that his cinematographer was his actual backbone, constantly asking what was in his head and how they should shoot it, holding the visual plan together while Shetty carried the performance (Bollywood Hungama, 2022). Read that carefully. The most acclaimed sequence in modern Kannada cinema rested partly on a cinematographer who made himself a stable spine for an overloaded director. That is honesty in the truest professional sense: subordinating ego to the needs of the scene and the person carrying it.

You can see the same ethic in his technical confessions. He does not pretend the divine climax was a feat of his own control. He insists it could only be captured because the performance was real and unrepeatable, and that his job was to be ready for it with two cameras and a small crew. He gives the credit outward, to the performer, to the ritual, to the team. That generosity is not just good manners. It is a working philosophy: the camera serves the moment, the cinematographer serves the director, and the best work happens when neither tries to dominate.

For a student, this is perhaps the least glamorous and most important lesson in the whole study. The temptation is to think the cinematographer's honesty lies in defending the perfect frame. Kashyap suggests the deeper honesty lies in knowing when the frame must bend to the performance, the budget, the location, or the exhausted human being directing the film. He bends, and the films are better for it.

11. Awards and Recognition

Recognition for Kashyap has come in two forms, and the more important one is harder to shelve. The films he has shot have been showered with honours. 777 Charlie won at the National Film Awards. Kantara took the Best Popular Film award at the 70th National Film Awards and a Silver Peacock Special Jury Award in the Indian Panorama section at the International Film Festival of India, while Rishab Shetty won Best Actor (Wikipedia, n.d.). These are not specifically cinematography prizes, but a cinematographer's reputation is built substantially on being the eye behind films the industry chooses to honour.

The critical recognition has been pointed and specific about his contribution. Writing in *The Hindu*, the reviewer praised his meditative shots for showcasing native culture and depicting rustic locales in their grandeur, singling out the Kambala sequences as evidence of his skill (Khajane, 2022). Across reviews of 777 Charlie, his cinematography was repeatedly called the technical highlight, the thing that turned a road trip into something cinematic (IndiaGlitz, 2022; Seta, 2022). That kind of recurring, by-name praise from critics is its own award, the slow accumulation of a reputation.

He has also earned the recognition of his peers and of the wider industry that matters most to a working cinematographer: the trust to shoot ever larger films, membership in the professional cinematography community signalled by the ISC affiliation that now follows his name, and the choice by a major lens maker to build a feature around his account of how he used their glass on Chapter 1. When the manufacturer of your lenses wants you to explain your craft, you have arrived as a cinematographer in the eyes of the people who make the tools. The honours on the films are real. The standing among those who actually know the work is the deeper recognition.

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12. Conclusion: Why He Is My Inspiration

I began this study wanting to separate the man from the noise of the hits, and I end it more convinced than when I started that the separation is worth making. Arvind Kashyap is not famous for a single beautiful image. He is significant for a way of thinking that I want to carry into my own work.

Three things will stay with me. The first is his refusal to be one kind of cinematographer. The same eye gave us the rooted, ritual world of Kantara, the roaming emotional geography of 777 Charlie and the loose comedy of the hostel film, and each time the grammar bent to the genre rather than the genre bending to a signature. Range, he taught me, is not a lack of a style. It is a style: the discipline of disappearing into each story.

The second is the marriage at the heart of his work, the one I keep returning to. He brings genuinely modern technique, the dolly zoom, the lens science, the three thousand effects shots, the aspect-ratio shifts, into the service of story-worlds that feel ancient and rooted. The Vertigo effect, made to summon a Daiva rather than frighten a thriller audience, is the whole man in one shot. He proves that the newest tools and the oldest stories are not enemies, that an engineer's precision can serve a believer's reverence, and that Kannada cinema can stand beside the best in the world without pretending to be from somewhere else.

The third is the quietest and, for me, the most instructive: his honesty. The honesty to keep an imperfection because it reads as true. The honesty to trust one unrepeatable take. The honesty to make himself the backbone of an overstretched director rather than the author of a private masterpiece. That is the kind of cinematographer I would like to become, one whose craft is total enough to vanish, and whose ego is small enough to serve.

He forgot, on purpose, to make me notice the camera. Then he reminded me, in one held breath, that someone was watching with me, with reverence, with patience, with belief. That is why he is my inspiration. Not because his frames are beautiful, though they are, but because they are honest, and they believe in the worlds they show. I am trying to learn to see like that.

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All web sources were accessed in June 2026. The study draws first on interviews in which the cinematographer speaks for himself, then on industry reporting and reviews, and finally on reference works for dates, credits and box-office figures. In evaluating these sources, I prioritised direct statements and interviews in which Arvind S. Kashyap discusses his own work, viewing these as the most reliable insight into his creative intentions. For industry reports and reviews, I gave greater weight to established publications and reviewers with recognised expertise in Indian cinema. I am aware that interviews may sometimes reflect the subject's perspective more than objective fact, and that reviews express opinion as well as analysis. Where possible, I cross-checked technical details and production accounts across multiple sources to ensure accuracy. However, certain technical aspects—such as the exact camera rigs, specific lens models used in particular scenes, or the full details of lighting setups—were not always verifiable due to a lack of published behind-the-scenes documentation or access to primary technical records. When information could not be confirmed, or gaps in sources existed, I have noted these limitations directly in the relevant sections. This approach is intended to be transparent about the strengths and limits of the available material, so that the reader can judge the evidence as clearly as possible.

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